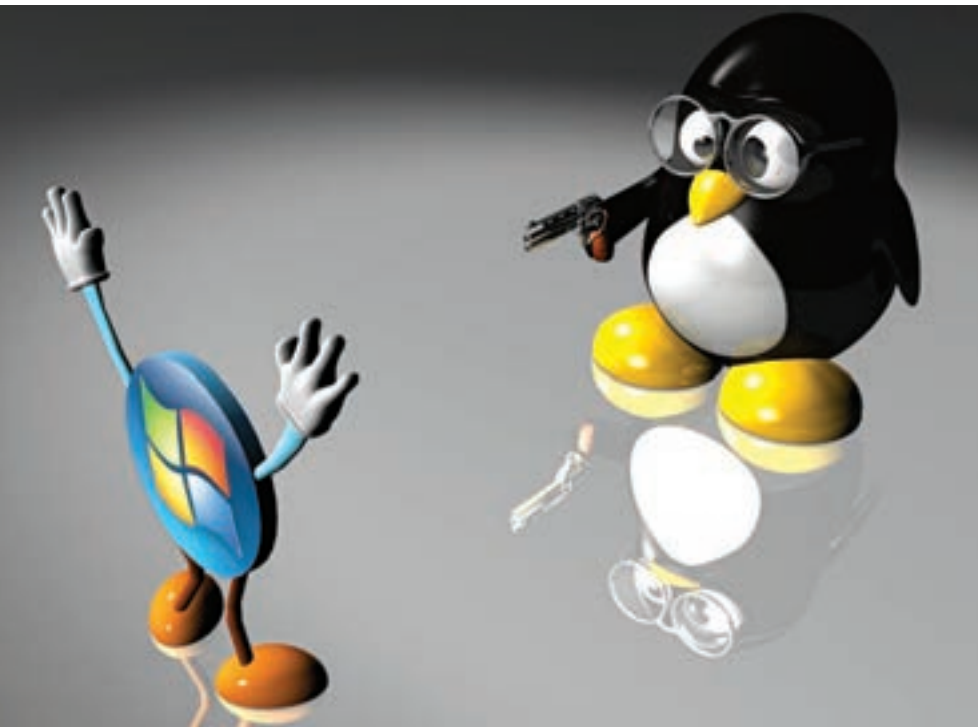




Friggin Fanboys!

Why do we get so predisposed to liking a particular product, software, operating system or even an ideology so much that we end up becoming unpaid advocates easily willing to slit each others throats?

Siddharth Parwatay
siddharth.parwatay@thinkdigit.com

As you would expect, we keep having a lot of heated debates in the Digit office on a daily basis. We're always at each other's throats about things ranging from evergreen debates such as ATI vs. NVIDIA, AMD vs. Intel, Windows vs. Mac, or even arguments on current issues like whether the Tumblr hipsters deserve to die at the hands of 4chan's anonymous legions. Yes, that last bit was about the ongoing war between the anarchist anonymous message board users from 4chan and their denial-of-service attack on Tumblr, the blogging platform populated by pseudo-intellectual, pseudo-net savvy idiots. The start of one such mini world war was when someone dropped a very casual statement in one of our edit meets; something to the effect of - "Winamp is so much better than

Windows Media Player". That was all we needed to set aside our agenda for the meeting and launch off into a skirmish over the most OMG-awesome media player in the universe. Soon Foobar, Mediamonkey and Media Play Classic were also thrown into the fray. Some die hard Winamp fanboys who have been using Winamp since the time their playlist consisted of Ace of Base tracks, defended their beloved player, mainly citing usability. "Can you even queue songs in Windows Media Player? And unlike WMP, you don't need to add everything to your library to be able to play stuff". Now hold on. Before you take a deep breath to launch off into a counter argument in response to the slightly misinformed statement above, rest assured, WMP fanboys landed on this particular Digit team member like a ton of bricks. So what exactly is it with Fanboyism? Why do we get so predisposed to liking

a particular product, software, operating system or even an ideology - razor sharp edges on a Mac Book anyone? In this feature, we'll look at some of the most fanatic fanboy groups that have existed throughout geek history and some newer emerging ones. But what's more important is a look at what forms biases; what are the factors that make us behave like mule-headed zealots. Come on, it's got to do with more than just people like Steve Jobs strutting around on stage in a black turtle neck right?

Psychology of Fanboyism

Wikipedia and Urban Dictionary have some interesting definitions for the phenomenon. The former says "Fanboy is a term used to describe a male who is highly devoted and biased in opinion towards a single subject or hobby within a given field. Fanboy-ism is often prevalent in a field of products, brands or universe of characters where very few competitors (or enemies in fiction, such as comics) exist." If you're a fangirl and are offended about the definition not covering the fairer sex, you should be glad. Only men are pig-headed (read:egoistic) enough to defend their trivial choices with such vigor.

By swaggering about as fanboys whether on the web or in real life, people inadvertently become not connoisseurs (or 1337) but rather unpaid advocates (or evangelists sic) of the company or product they're defending. So lets get down to the fundamental question - what causes the bias?

Familiarity - People familiar with something are obviously predisposed to liking it and extolling its virtues. This is one of the prime reasons why Windows users have trouble transitioning to Linux (when they are forced to) and hence launch off into lengthy litanies on the subject of operating systems.

Elitism and Esoterism - Being a part of a small club exclusive club is something people have been seeking since time immemorial. By owning or using something you believe is not consumed by the masses you feel special somehow. The key word however is believe. There are still some people out there who